FOREWORD

This book is an autobiographical account of Nambi Narayanan, who is Nambi for his friends at the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). From his early days in ISRO I knew him as an intelligent, hardworking and dedicated scientist with unquestionable integrity.

By watching him from a distance, I could see the potential of Nambi and I started closely associating with him on different occasions. As a director at ISRO headquarters, I had the opportunity to understand his eagerness to develop liquid propulsion technology for India. Nambi studied liquid propulsion technology in Princeton University, USA, with a NASA Fellowship. He secured his Master's degree in a record time of less than a year.

Prof Satish Dhawan gave all his support to Nambi to jointly develop the Vikas engine with a French company called SEP. I happened to closely associate with Nambi during this period. His excellent performance with very limited manpower under stringent financial constraints enabled India to master the Vikas engine technology.

This highly reliable engine was flight-tested in PSLV and, ever since 1994, continues to perform without a single failure. Nambi is much like this engine that came out of several trials by fire. He was falsely implicated in the ISRO spy case and arrested in November 1994. A CBI inquiry later found the case to be false – something which everyone who knew Nambi closely was sure about – and found fault with some officers of the Intelligence Bureau and the Kerala Police who investigated the case.

Besides documenting his trials, Nambi elaborates in this book the evolution of ISRO from its inception to the present. ISRO is a great